



Figure 6: Twitter.com screenshot shows the tweets from BTI

Enter twitter password: mypassword

tweet: This is a test tweet from #btl client.

As you can see in the snippet above, the password is not blanked out, which we generally expect from any other command line utility. I hope they fix it in future releases.

BTI also supports a configuration file. You can place a *.bti* file in your home directory (*~/bti*), which looks like the following:

```
# comments are allowed in the bti config file
account=twitmaster
password=mypassword
host=identica
# Example of a custom laconica installation
#host=http://army.twit.tv/api/statuses
logfile=.bti.log
#action=update
#user=gregkh
#proxy=http://localhost:8080
#shrink-urls=yes
```

This saves you from typing your credentials every time you want to use a service.

It has many command line options for tweeting. For example, you can shorten a URL using the *—shrink-urls* option. A shell script called *bti-shrink-urls* takes care of the shortening business.

```
tweet: This is a test tweet to test URL shortening http://www.google.com/
search?q=stylelen&ie=utf-8&oe=utf-8&aq=t&rls=org.debian:en-US:unofficial&cl
ient=iceweasel-a
```

Figure 6 shows the tweets from Twitter.com that we've posted using BTI. Anyway, there's not much you can do using BTI besides posting your updates.

Twidge

Twidge is another command line client and supports *identi.ca* and Twitter. It can be used in an automated way to post *to the services*, and can also be interactive. Twidge is easy to use and it's highly customisable to fit your needs as well.

It is mandatory to have the 'twidgerc' file in your home folder, in order to use this app. Twidge can create '*~/twidgerc*' automatically when you run *twidge setup* by interactively asking questions about your account:

```
stylelen@vanji:~$ twidge setup
Welcome to twidge. We will now configure twidge for your
use. This will be quick and easy!
```



Figure 7: Twitter.com screenshot shows the tweets from Twidge

First, what is your username?

Username: testsen

Welcome, testsen! Now I'll need your password.

Password:

twidge has now been configured for you.

There are lots of configuration parameters that could go into the configuration file. All of these are available in the man pages or you can get the manual from <http://software.complete.org/static/twidge/doc/twidge.pdf>. A sample configuration file for Twidge is as follows:

```
[DEFAULT]
password: mypassword
username: testsen
```

A sample run to post on Twitter follows:

```
stylelen@vanji:~$ twidge update "This is a test tweet from
#twidge client."
stylelen@vanji:~$ twidge update "This is a test for
URL shortening from #twidge http://www.google.com/
search?stylelen&ie=utf-8&oe=utf-8&aq=t&rls=org.debian:en-US:
unofficial&client=iceweasel-a
stylelen@vanji:~$
```

Figure 7 shows the posted tweets from Twitter.com.

It supports URL shortening with *tinyurl.com*. You can integrate it with your email system in order to send and receive updates in the form of emails. With the *dmSEND* option, it is possible to send direct messages too.

Postscript

Of course, this article does not give an entire list of all desktop clients available for microblogging—my purpose was to just discuss some of those I've used. In fact, all you Pidgin users might not need a separate app for microblogging—the 'micro-blog purple' plug-in can be good fun. Likewise, you can install the Echofon Firefox extension also. And well, it doesn't stop there. If you know Python, you can cook up your own client with the 'Python-Twitter' module. Happy microblogging! 

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